

Oldest Pet Burial Ground in America Is Final Resting Place for Thousands

On most days, Mark Lindenberg either drives or walks over to visit with Boots, his beloved cat who died in 2020 at 17 years old. The New York man had the animal buried at the Hartsdale Pet Cemetery, a burial place on small grassy hills near the main road.

The words on Boots' tombstone read, "You taught me how to love and be loved."

Other tombstones include phrases such as "A truer friend we never had" and "Our beloved queen."

"Human cemeteries are sad," Lindenberg said. "This is one of the most cheerful places."

He added, "I can't think of a better place."

Hartsdale is America's oldest pet cemetery in operation. It was added to the National Register of Historic Places in 2012. Lindenberg says he paid about \$7,000 to bury Boots at Hartsdale. Those costs cover the individual site, burial, burial container, tombstone, and grounds care.

"What have I worked for if I'm not going to do the things that matter most, and this mattered most," Lindenberg said. "I got instant closure the day I decided I was going to bury her here."

Mark Lindenberg visits the grave of his pet cat, Boots, who is buried at the Hartsdale Pet Cemetery, located about 30 kilometers outside of New York City. (VOA)

Pet burials started in Hartsdale in 1896 when animal doctor Samuel Johnson let a woman bury her dog on his property of apple trees. The place is about 30 kilometers north of New York City.

Since that time, about 70,000 animals have been laid to rest in the two-hectare cemetery. Most of the pets buried at Hartsdale are cats and dogs, but several other kinds of animals are also there.

"There's reptiles that are buried here. Mice," said Edward Martin III, vice president of the Hartsdale Pet Cemetery. "There's a lion cub that was buried here in 1912 by a Russian princess. There's the ashes of Ming, who's a Bengal tiger that was buried here a few years ago. There are some monkeys."

There is also Hudson the horse, some birds and singer Mariah Carey's cat, Clarence. The oldest headstone, dating to 1898, remembers the life of a dog named Blague.

Martin operates the place with his father Edward Martin Jr., who purchased the cemetery in 1974. The younger Martin is a lawyer and accountant who decided later in his career to help run the cemetery. He had worked there also as a teenager.

The Hartsdale Pet Cemetery, America's oldest working pet cemetery, was added to the National Register of Historic Places in 2012. (VOA)

"I've seen what people go through, and they lose their pets, and I feel like I'm in a good position where I can help them," he said. "And I have helped them, and it makes me want to continue helping them."

Between 250 and 300 burials take place at Hartsdale each year. The cemetery never runs out of space because not all of the burial sites are permanent. People can make a one-time forever maintenance payment of \$3,500 or a yearly payment of \$105. If the yearly payments stop, that gravesite is offered for sale.

"The pet in the grave will be removed from that plot so someone else who wants it can pay the maintenance. And the pets are taken out, and they're cremated, and they don't leave the cemetery," said Martin Jr., Hartsdale's president. "Their remains are scattered over the cemetery grass."

A centerpiece at the cemetery is the war dog memorial at the top of a hill. Established in 1923, the memorial honored World War I service dogs. But these days, the memorial honors service dogs of all kinds.

More than 70,000 animals have been buried at the Hartsdale Pet Cemetery in Hartsdale, New York. (VOA)

Although Hartsdale is mostly a resting place for animals, the cremated remains of about 800 humans are buried here with their pets. There is a Martin family plot, where the elder Martin plans to be laid to rest when he dies.

"I have to be buried somewhere. And why would I go to any place other than this?" he said. "My mother and father, and my mother-in-law or father-in-law are buried here, and so, that's a good reason by itself to do it."

Lindenberg also likes the idea. He has already prepared to be cremated and buried alongside Boots when the time comes.

"I'm single. I don't know if I'll ever get married, and I can't think of a better place," he said. "I lived with my cat every day for almost 17 years. Why stop now?"

In the meantime, Lindenberg, who lives a 10-minute walk away, will continue to visit his old friend almost daily.

I'm Caty Weaver.

Dora Mekouar reported this story for VOA News. Caty Weaver adapted the story for Learning English.

Vocabulary

tombstone - n. ป้ายหลุมศพ

cheerful - adj. สดใส, ร่าเริง, แจ่มใส

instant - n. เกิดขึ้นอย่างรวดเร็วทันที, ฉับพลัน

cub - n. ลูกสัตว์ (เช่น ลูกหมี, ลูกสิงโต, ลูกเสือ)

princess - n. เจ้าหญิง

cremate - v. เผาศพ

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the primary reason Mark Lindenberg visits Hartsdale Pet Cemetery regularly?

- A) To visit the grave of his beloved cat, Boots.
- B) To help with the cemetery's maintenance.
- C) To meet other pet owners.
- D) To enjoy the small grassy hills.

2. What message is inscribed on Boots' tombstone?

- A) "A truer friend we never had."
- B) "Our beloved queen."
- C) "You taught me how to love and be loved."
- D) "Always in our hearts."

3. How does Mark Lindenberg describe the atmosphere of Hartsdale Pet Cemetery compared to human cemeteries?

- A) It is equally sad.
- B) It is a more cheerful place.
- C) It is confusing and quiet.
- D) It is a place of deep sorrow.

4. Which of the following statements about Hartsdale Pet Cemetery is true, according to Paragraph 7?

- A) It was founded in 2012.
- B) It is the newest pet cemetery in America.

- C) It was added to the National Register of Historic Places in 2012.
- D) The burial cost of \$7,000 only covers the individual site.

5. What was Mark Lindenberg's primary feeling after deciding to bury Boots at Hartsdale?

- A) Regret about the high cost.
- B) A sense of instant closure.
- C) Confusion about the process.
- D) A desire to move Boots to another location.

6. How did pet burials at Hartsdale originally begin?

- A) Mark Lindenberg started it for his cat.
- B) A Russian princess buried her lion cub.
- C) An animal doctor allowed a woman to bury her dog on his land.
- D) The cemetery was officially opened by the city in 1896.

7. Approximately how many animals have been buried at Hartsdale since its inception, and what are the most common types?

- A) 17 animals, mostly reptiles and monkeys.
- B) 800 animals, primarily horses and birds.
- C) 70,000 animals, mainly cats and dogs.
- D) 3,500 animals, with an even mix of all types.

8. Which unusual animal was buried at Hartsdale by a Russian princess in 1912?

- A) A Bengal tiger
- B) A lion cub
- C) A monkey
- D) A reptile

9. What is the name of the dog commemorated by the oldest headstone at Hartsdale?

- A) Hudson
- B) Clarence
- C) Blague
- D) Boots

10. What was Edward Martin III's profession before he decided to help run the Hartsdale Pet Cemetery?

- A) Animal doctor

- B) Historian
- C) Lawyer and accountant
- D) Grounds keeper

11. What motivates Edward Martin III to continue working at the pet cemetery?

- A) The financial benefits of running the business.
- B) The joy of seeing various animal species buried there.
- C) The desire to help people cope with the loss of their pets.
- D) His family tradition dating back to 1896.

12. According to Paragraph 17, why does the Hartsdale Pet Cemetery never run out of space?

- A) They continuously expand into new land.
- B) Most pets are cremated and their ashes are scattered elsewhere.
- C) Not all burial sites are permanent, allowing for reuse.
- D) The number of new burials is very low each year.

13. What happens to a pet's remains if yearly maintenance payments for its gravesite stop?

- A) The remains are given back to the owner.
- B) The remains are moved to a different pet cemetery.
- C) The pet is removed, cremated, and its ashes are scattered within the cemetery.
- D) The gravesite is permanently abandoned, but the pet remains.

14. What is the current purpose of the war dog memorial at Hartsdale?

- A) To honor only World War I service dogs.
- B) To commemorate all animals buried in the cemetery.
- C) To honor service dogs of all kinds, not just those from WWI.
- D) To mark the oldest burial site in the cemetery.

15. Besides pets, what other remains are buried at Hartsdale Pet Cemetery?

- A) Artifacts from the Civil War.
- B) The cremated remains of approximately 800 humans.
- C) Remains of wild animals found on the property.
- D) Historical documents related to the cemetery's founding.